

Title: Choking First Aid

Excerpt: Over 5,000 people in the United States die from choking every year. Many are aware of the risks, but few actually know what to do in case of emergency. Read this manual so you can be prepared to quickly take action and save somebody from choking – a couple seconds can be the difference between life and death.

Authors: Fiona Cheng

Editor: Sophie Jin

Artist:

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You walk in a restaurant and then your server sits you down. You pick up the menu and think about what your tastebuds are craving. Just as you signal a waiter over, you notice a frantic commotion growing in the far distance. You look over and see a man clutching both hands to his throat, his skin losing hue, turning grey, producing nothing but a strained, wheezing breath of air.

Then it hits you – you remember this all too well from your CPR certification course. *Both hands gripping the throat. Unable to speak. Noisy, labored breathing. Lips turning blue.* This is choking: every second counts, so don't hesitate and save him.

First, ask somebody nearby to call the local emergency number (e.g. 911). Then begin the "5 and 5" method – 5 back blows and 5 abdominal thrusts (Heimlich Maneuver). To start the back blows, you position yourself to the side of the choking person. Place one hand diagonally across his chest and guide his back parallel to the ground with your other hand. With the base of your palm, firmly strike in between the shoulder blades 5 separate times. To switch to the 5 abdominal thrusts, first guide them to an upright position. Place your two fingers on the man's navel (belly button) and position your front foot in between his legs to provide stability. With your other hand, make a fist and press it against his abdomen (stomach) right above your positioned two fingers. Take your first hand and grasp your fist with that hand, then press it to the abdomen to create quick, inward-and-upward motions 5 times. Repeat these steps until the blockage is removed.

If the person becomes unconscious: First, lower them carefully onto the floor, face up with their arms at their sides. If you can visibly see the blockage at the back of the throat, sweep it out with a finger. If the choking person does not respond, begin CPR with chest compressions and rescue breaths, checking the mouth for the object regularly.

If you cannot get your arms all the way around their midsection: Rather than abdominal thrusts, start by placing the thrusts on their sternum (breastbone), just above where the lowest ribs meet, and apply firm thrusts.

If the choking victim is an infant younger than 1 year old: Sit down and hold the infant face-down on your forearm. Using the base of your palm, gently but firmly thump 5 times on the middle of the back. If there is still no response, turn the infant face-up on your forearm with the head kept lower than the trunk. Place two fingers at the center of the breastbone, and deliver 5 quick chest compressions. Repeat the back blows and chest compressions until breathing resumes or emergency help arrives.

At last, the man coughs and reclaims their breathing. You have just saved someone's life because you knew exactly what to do. Choking is one of the leading causes of accidental death, but it is also one of the most preventable. Informing yourself with articles on what to do is a strong first step, but the most optimal way is to get yourself certified. Look into a CPR and first-aid course in your local area through the American Red Cross or American Heart Association. Don't wait to learn until it's too late.